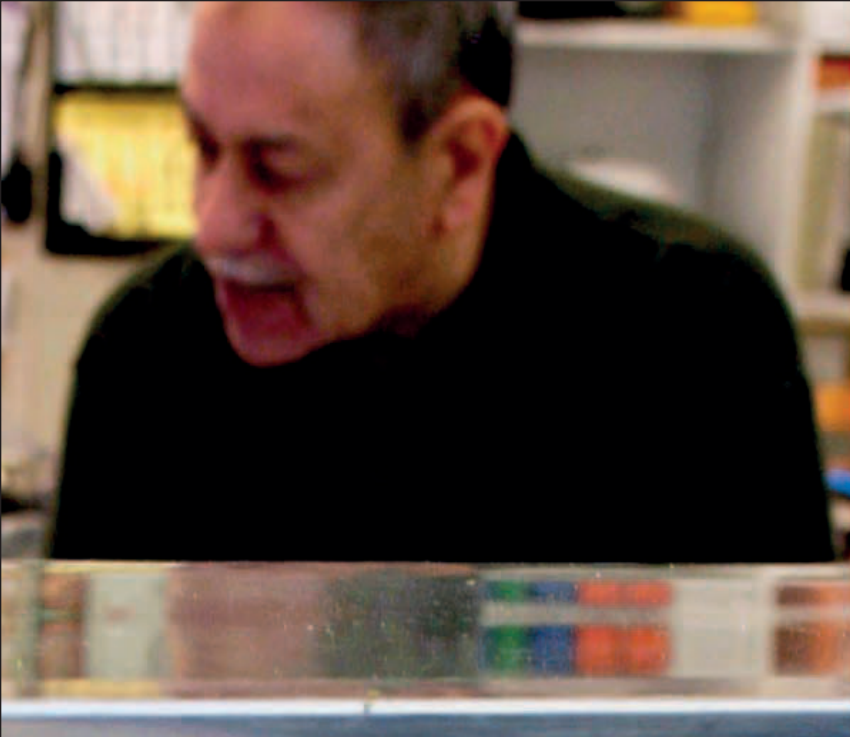




Above Carefully graded pistachios grown locally fill the bazaars in Gaziantep

Left A pastry counter in Gaziantep, with fresh-baked baklava in the foreground; the sweet may contain up to 70 layers of pastry



Above The ancient Kale, or walled citadel, was in use as a defensive structure until the end of the Ottoman empire in the early 20th century

Other Sweet Treats

An old and oft-quoted Turkish saying goes “Eat sweet; talk sweet,” and **tatlılar** (candy and desserts) play a vital role in Turkish cultural life, accompanying many of life’s major events. At engagements and weddings, **baklava** is the traditional gift; **lokma** (fried dough balls in syrup) and **helva** (halva) are associated with funerals, as well as New Year, and a piece of **Turkish delight** wrapped in muslin is traditionally placed between the lips of a newborn child. Modern Turkish cookbooks list up to 300 sweet recipes, many bearing evocative names including **hoşmerim** (meaning “Something nice for my brave man”).

The Best Places to Eat Baklava

İmam Çağdaş

moderate—expensive

Family-run **İmam Çağdaş** is arguably Gaziantep’s best *baklavacı* (baklava shop). The eponymous owner, **Burhan Çağdaş**, grandson of **İmam Dede** who founded the pastry shop in 1887, exports his little boxes of baklava daily all across the country and abroad too, including, it is rumored, to Turkey’s premier himself, President Abdullah Gül. Burhan sustains his success and high standards by using only high-quality, organic ingredients hand-selected from carefully sourced local producers. Though the recently relocated pastry shop itself is unremarkable, decorated in a plain, contemporary style, it is on the excellence of his pastries that Burhan has continued the **Çağdaş** family reputation. According to Burhan, his baklava should be eaten not with the knife and fork supplied but with the thumb and index finger, placing the baklava in the top of the mouth and then biting down. The *baklavacı* is open all day, serving pastries with coffee and preparing parcels of baklava for its customers to take away.

Eski Hal Civarı, Uzun Çarşı 47, Şahinbey, Gaziantep; +90 342 231 2678

Also in Gaziantep

Çavuşoğlu (+90 342 231 3069; moderate) has a good reputation as both a *baklavacı* and a *kebabçı* (kebab house) and is a good choice for a complete Turkish meal. Food is fresh, well-prepared, and well-priced and the baklava are legendary. Other famous Gaziantep *baklavacı*s well worth visiting include **Baclava Ünlüler (+90 342 232 2043; inexpensive—moderate)**, and **Fıstıkzade (+90 342 336 0020; inexpensive—moderate)**, both in the center of town.

Also in Turkey

Karaköy Güllüoğlu (+90 212 293 0910; moderate—expensive) opened in Istanbul in 1949, the first in a series of famous *baklavacı*s owned by the Güllü family. From the tantalizing pastry counter, customers can choose a *porsiyon* (portion) of whatever baklava takes their fancy, including *cevizli* (the walnut variety), *fıstıklı* (pistachio), or *sade* (plain).

Around the World

Güllüoğlu (718 645 1822; expensive) in Brooklyn, New York, is the first American branch of the famous Turkish chain founded by the Güllü family (see above). The bakers are trained in Istanbul and ingredients are flown in daily from Turkey.

